

Energy and Environment Outlook

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【メール原文】

Europe's gas inventories should be sufficient for winter, with Italy above 80% and Germany at 53% as of early September. While stocks should last thro|||||||

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Europe has enough gas in storage with little room for error

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Europe has (just) enough gas to carry it through winter

By Henning Gloystein

Europe's main natural gas inventories will likely be sufficient to carry industries and households through the winter heating season. Although inventories in Germany and Italy, the EU's two biggest gas consumers, are lower than the five-year average, they will probably last them through the end of winter in March 2027.

Outlook:

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Italy has largely filled its natural gas inventories well ahead of winter, with Montel storage data showing that stocks exceeded 80%, or nearly 170 TWh, by the end of August. That level gives Italy almost 60 days of winter gas supply, excluding other supply sources. If Italy reaches full inventories of 195 TWh by 1 November, stocks would likely cover about 70 days of winter demand, again excluding other sources of supply.

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Germany, by contrast, had filled only 53% of its gas inventories as of 1 September. Those 130 TWh would provide about 40 days of peak winter gas supply. If Germany has 185-190 TWh in storage by November, it should have enough gas to meet about 50 days of peak winter demand.

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Given that Germany and Italy are Europe's largest gas consumers, Europe's winter gas inventories will probably be sufficient to carry the region through the winter. However, prices will likely remain elevated and could rise further if winter is unusually cold or prolonged or if additional unplanned supply disruptions occur (note: Energy & Resources: EU will likely scrape through winter on tighter gas reserves , 13 August 2026).

New executive order raises risks for Chinese tech in US grid

By Herbert Crowther

US President Donald Trump's administration is intensifying its campaign against Chinese technology in the power grid through a new executive order issued on 26 August. The order declares a national emergency over the risk that foreign adversaries could infiltrate the grid and establishes new policies to scrutinize imported equipment. It applies to a wide range of technologies defined as "bulk power system electrical equipment" and covers all imports. In practice, however, the administration will likely focus primarily on Chinese-linked inputs. The move also marks the latest step in line with Eurasia Group's earlier assessment that Washington and Brussels would treat grid equipment as both a cyber risk and an industrial opportunity (see: Energy & Resources: EU and US will likely deepen policy support for grid tech , 29 July 2026).

Outlook:

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This order gives the Department of Energy (DOE) broad discretion to classify technologies, vendors, and projects as high risk. Once DOE makes that determination, it and other agencies can bar foreign inputs from a project or transaction. DOE will likely focus first on sensitive nodes, such as grid-connected inverters, rather than on battery energy storage systems (BESS).

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The order is also the administration's first sign that it may seek to remove existing Chinese grid inputs. It introduces new scrutiny of cyber risks for existing assets and raises the possibility of "rip and replace" measures. That step would escalate beyond the Federal Communications Commission's (FCC) action targeting inverter imports in July. The FCC move applied only to future inverter models, not existing projects. DOE is instructed to "consider effects on reliability and safety" before requiring the removal of any inputs.

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This order indicates that space for Chinese inputs in the US grid is shrinking. Long-term policy risks for Chinese suppliers seeking approval for US projects are rising, regardless of any near-term US-China truce and President Xi Jinping's planned 24 September visit to Washington (see: Managed decoupling will define US-China relations through 2031 , 27 August 2026).

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Like the FCC inverter action, this order allows DOE to establish an exemption list of prequalified firms and equipment. Firms that commit to US onshoring plans and take steps to reduce cyber-related risks will likely receive favorable treatment from DOE.

EU carbon border policy will tighten Turkey's carbon market over time

By Conor Frydenborg, Jesus Renzullo

Turkey has launched the pilot phase of its first carbon-pricing mechanism after its Emissions Trading System (ETS) regulation entered into force on 27 August. The framework implements the 2025 Climate

Law, which sets the legal basis for reaching net-zero emissions by 2053, and brings into the ETS installations that emit more than 50,000 tons of CO₂-equivalent a year. The ETS reflects not only decarbonization goals but also industrial and trade policy priorities. The EU is Turkey's largest export market, and the EU Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) began imposing financial obligations in January on imports not already covered by carbon-pricing schemes. Because payments made under Turkey's ETS will reduce CBAM liabilities, Ankara is following a broader trend among EU trading partners that are adapting to, rather than resisting, CBAM (see: Energy and Environment Outlook: EU will pair looser emissions trading rules with expanded carbon tariffs , 18 June 2026).

Outlook:

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EU CBAM pressure will gradually make the ETS more consequential. The government had previously planned a 2026-2027 pilot focused on CBAM-exposed sectors, followed by broader implementation from 2028. However, the final regulation leaves the timing and sectoral scope to a later decision by the Carbon Market Board. Ankara will probably maintain the same general direction. Steel, cement, aluminum, and other EU-facing industries having the strongest incentive to establish a recognized domestic carbon price, as CBAM changes rise alongside the EU's phaseout of free ETS allowances through 2034. As the EU appears set to expand the scope of the CBAM, both across sectors and by-product coverage, pressure on Ankara to tighten its ETS will increase.

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Ankara will initially prioritize industrial competitiveness over a high carbon price. The Carbon Market Board has broad discretion over free allocations, allowance supply, and price-management tools, and the ETS cap is based on emissions intensity rather than a fixed ceiling on total emissions. This approach gives the government substantial room to limit costs for politically important energy-intensive industries. The pilot will therefore likely serve mainly as a compliance and market-building exercise, supported by generous free allocations and intervention to prevent carbon prices from rising quickly.

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Political resistance suggests Turkey's ETS will be materially less stringent than the EU's. The Climate Law drew opposition both from critics who saw carbon markets as externally imposed and from those who argued that the legislation was not ambitious enough. However, the Carbon Market Board gives the government extensive control over how it implements the ETS. Its main initial priority will be to avoid new costs for industry amid persistent competitiveness and cost-of-living concerns. As a result, Turkey will probably deepen its carbon pricing only gradually.

Copper prices can rise as long as governments keep hoarding

By Timothy Puko, Conor Frydenborg

Copper prices reached fresh record highs in August and could rise further as government-driven stockpiling tightened supply. In early August, news reports unsettled the market by revealing that the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), Africa's largest copper producer, had quietly banned exports of copper and cobalt concentrates in June. On 17 August, the Export-Import Bank of Korea said it would lend Glencore \$1 billion to secure copper supplies for South Korean companies during the loan period. Copper prices hit record highs twice that month, most recently reaching \$6.71 per pound for US futures on 25 August.

Outlook:

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Supply concerns will keep governments stockpiling. The moves from Kinshasa and Seoul support Eurasia Group's call that fears over copper supply would prompt governments, directly or indirectly, to hoard the metal (see: Energy and Environment Outlook: Growing stockpile programs are ushering in an era of global hoarding , 23 April 2026). Rising global instability has increased the urgency of economic security and military development. As a result, governments now consider it a strategic priority to ensure reliable access to materials used in weapons, electrification, and advanced technologies, especially AI. There is no clear end in sight for this trend.

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US copper tariff decisions are the next major signpost. A trade investigation by the Trump administration last year outlined recommendations that could lead to gradual tariffs on copper or copper derivatives in the coming months. The White House will likely preserve flexibility rather than impose tariffs immediately. Still, the tariff threat has already encouraged traders to move large volumes of copper into US warehouses ahead of any decision. That dynamic supports the goal of US officials to increase domestic supply and, in effect, creates a de facto US stockpile.

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Economic contraction—and little else—could quickly reverse the market. If the AI bubble were to burst or a broader economic contraction took hold, prices would likely fall because US stockpiles are so high. For now, however, governments remain focused on securing supply—regardless of market conditions—by generating enough buying pressure to support prices, even with the risk of excess copper sitting in US storage.

China is likely to succeed in rebranding its minerals strategy

By Timothy Puko

Chinese President Xi Jinping used his appearance at the Shanghai Cooperation Organization meetings to emphasize “green minerals” and closer cooperation around Beijing's overseas mining investments. Xi elevated the initiative to a top priority in a way he had not before, showing how far Beijing is willing to go to strengthen its geostrategic advantage by dominating mineral markets. The effort is also a rebranding campaign. Beijing wants to reassure international partners that its mining operations can deliver economic and environmental benefits. China faces broad concern that it could weaponize its dominance of supply chains against geopolitical rivals and criticism over environmental damage tied to some of its African mining operations.

Outlook:

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Instability from Washington could help Beijing win support. China first announced its green mining initiative with 19 countries at last year's G20 summit. The announcement came amid backlash to newly imposed export controls on critical minerals and over dam collapses allegedly linked to Chinese mining operations in the Democratic Republic of Congo and Zambia. Since then, Beijing has used the initiative and other outreach efforts to repair those relationships and reassure partners. If Beijing can follow through on its promises of benevolence and limit environmental damage from its operations, its rebranding effort will probably succeed and yield dividends. That outcome will become more likely if Washington continues to alienate its allies and many countries view the US as a greater source of instability.

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China's willingness to invest in partner countries exposes a competitive gap its rivals cannot close. Although Beijing will not fund processing and refining infrastructure abroad, it is willing to build rail networks, roads, ports, and other badly needed assets. The US is either unable or unwilling to offer comparable benefits, leaving China well positioned to deepen its dominance of mineral markets while building broader political influence in resource-rich countries.

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The bigger risk for competitors is that China's model is self-reinforcing. By investing in infrastructure for mineral access, Beijing embeds its institutions in local economies in ways that are difficult to reverse. As that buildout expands, the combined effects of Chinese capital, influence, and supply chain control make it progressively harder to compete—not just in mineral markets but across broader economic relationships.

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